

Guài: Generative Myths of Machine Perception

Monica Lim
University of Melbourne
Melbourne, Australia
monica.lim1@unimelb.edu.au

Mindy Meng Wang
University of Melbourne
Melbourne, Australia
mindy@mindymengwang.com

Jingcheng Wang
University of Melbourne
Melbourne, Australia
jingcheng.wang@unimelb.edu.au

Mel Huang Buntine
University of Melbourne
Melbourne, Australia
mel.huang@unimelb.edu.au

Andrew Mahisa Halim
University of Melbourne
Melbourne, Australia
amhalim@student.unimelb.edu.au

Zhengzi Jiang
University of Melbourne
Melbourne, Australia
jiangzhengzi@hotmail.com

YuHin Li
University of Melbourne
Melbourne, Australia
sean.li@student.unimelb.edu.au

Adelaide Genay
University of Melbourne
Melbourne, Australia
adelaide.genay@unimelb.edu.au

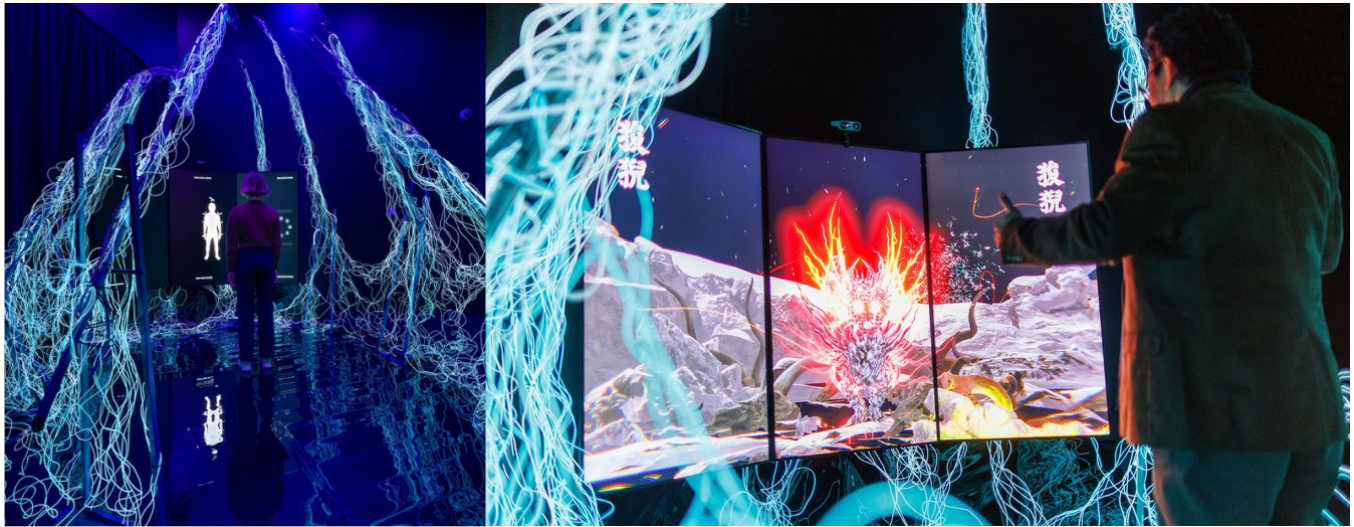


Figure 1: Guài is an artificial intelligence-based mixed reality mirror that predicts the user’s personality, similarly to traditional Chinese face reading practices. Predictions are used to match users with a monster avatar inspired by Chinese mythology.

Abstract

Guài is an interactive mixed reality installation that challenges dominant narratives around artificial intelligence (AI), identity, and cultural epistemology. Drawing on the mythological bestiary of the Chinese classic *Shan Hai Jing* (“Classic of Mountains and Seas”), Guài uses AI to analyse biometric attributes and match participants to fantastical monsters. Each participant is immersed in a personalised soundscape, generated from their biometric data and

combining sonic storytelling with contemporary data-driven profiling. Through a body tracking game, Guài invites participants into a fluid cycle of “continuous becoming”, self-perception, transformation, and confrontation, mirroring how generative systems perpetually reshape identity and agency. The installation stages a tension between ancient and algorithmic modes of prediction, offering critique of the opaque logic behind AI and its reproduction of normative bias, while proposing speculative, non-Western modes of being and knowing. In doing so, Guài embodies a critical, mythopoetic response to the cultural and technological forces shaping our generative futures.

ACM Reference Format:

Monica Lim, Mindy Meng Wang, Jingcheng Wang, Mel Huang Buntine, Andrew Mahisa Halim, Zhengzi Jiang, YuHin Li, and Adelaide Genay. 2025. Guài: Generative Myths of Machine Perception. In *SIGGRAPH Asia 2025 Art Gallery (SA Art Gallery '25)*, December 15–18, 2025, Hong Kong, Hong Kong. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 2 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3757368.3765543>

Permission to make digital or hard copies of all or part of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).
SA Art Gallery '25, Hong Kong, Hong Kong
© 2025 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).
ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1883-0/25/12
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3757368.3765543>

1 Artist Statement

Guài emerged from our observation of participants engaging with an AI-based biometric analysis interface by Wouters et al. [2019]. Many became emotional and invested in the analysis outputs, comparing them to their self-perception, without knowing or understanding how the AI was trained or possibly biased. This motivated us to create an interactive work that invites the public to question how emerging technologies mediate identity.

We decided to play with the idea of AI revealing our inner monster. This inspired the title Guài, which means 'strange' or 'monster' in Mandarin. In Chinese face reading, an ancient philosophy practised for centuries, facial attributes are linked to human characteristics and are believed to indicate not only health and personality, but also future fortunes. Guài draws on this tradition: we were interested in its parallel with algorithmic processes, which present themselves as objective and yet remain entangled with inherited cultural assumptions, biases, and histories of seeing.

Rather than taking a didactic approach, we wanted to create a playful interaction where participants reflect on the implications of technology through their own experience of being analysed, categorised, and assigned to one of eight monsters from the *Shan Hai Jing* ("Classic of Mountains and Seas"). The installation opens a liminal space where participants confront how algorithmic systems perceive them—through data, myth, and mediated embodiment. By transforming participants into monstrous avatars, Guài disorients normative notions of virtue and selfhood, and draws attention to the cultural specificity embedded within seemingly neutral technologies.

Guài proposes that the generative is not limited to real-time outputs or AI synthesis; it also resides in the encounter itself, where historical and computational systems generate new meanings through their friction with human bodies and play. The work invites participants to consider how these systems not only create artefacts but actively shape identity, belief, and becoming.

2 Summary of Participant Experience

As the participant enters the installation, a friendly voice greets them, introducing itself as a sentient AI aiming to generate an avatar that faithfully represents them. A photo of the participant's face is then captured and analysed to predict the participant's age and gender, along with a percentage rating of eight personality traits: happiness, boringness, morality, virtue, moral virtue, intelligence, weirdness, and egoism.

After presenting these results, the narrator reveals the participant's assigned avatar and provides a brief description of its personality and mythical powers. A soundtrack custom-designed to the participant's data begins to play, generated using a database of layered sound samples, ranging from acoustic elements to rhythmic beats and synthesised textures.

Next, the participant is invited to play a game where they must catch fireballs to evolve their avatar, using body tracking. As they interact, the interactive sound emphasises their movements, successes in catching fireballs, and when 'levelling up', providing a greater sense of connection between the participant's body and their virtual avatar.

The experience ends when they reach the third and final form, or after a timeout. Finally, a 'gamecard' summarising the user's predicted characteristics is displayed on-screen with a QR code to allow downloading a copy of it.

Acknowledgments

The authors would like to thank Dr Qiushi Zhou and Dr Antony Chacon for their previous contribution to an earlier version of this project, and Henry Lai-Pyne for the avatar design. Thank you also to the School of Computing and Information Systems and Museums and Collections at the University of Melbourne for their support.

3 Project URL

<https://www.monicalim.online/guai>

References

- Niels Wouters, Ryan Kelly, Eduardo Velloso, Katrin Wolf, Hasan Shahid Ferdous, Joshua Newn, Zaher Joukhadar, and Frank Vetere. 2019. Biometric Mirror: Exploring Ethical Opinions towards Facial Analysis and Automated Decision-Making. In *Proceedings of the 2019 on Designing Interactive Systems Conference*. ACM, San Diego CA USA, 447–461. doi:10.1145/3322276.3322304